



EXPLORING NEW HORIZONS IN VIDEO GAME CULTURES



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NICK WEBBER, EWAN KIRKLAND
& RENÉ REINHOLD SCHALLENGER (EDS)

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Video Games as Safe Spaces: A Walking Perspective

Kseniia Harshina and Tom Tucek

Introduction

The concept of ‘safe spaces’ has evolved significantly since its emergence in the women’s liberation movement of the late twentieth century (Kenney, 2001: 24). Originally rooted in feminist and queer activism, the idea of a safe space was associated with environments where marginalised groups could gather free from the threat of violence – not only physical but also verbal and emotional violence (Roestone Collective, 2014: 1346). The terms ‘safe’ and ‘safety’ are thus defined here by the absence of all these forms of violence. The Roestone Collective categorises safe spaces into separatist ones, inclusive ones, and object-attentive ones. The separatist, highly controlled safe spaces originally functioned as sites of resistance against oppressive societal structures, but over time, the concept has expanded and been applied to various new contexts, including educational settings, online communities, and, more recently, video games (Scheuerman, Branham, and Hamidi, 2018). Furthermore, there have also been numerous misappropriations and criticisms; for example, Ali (2017: 3) highlights how critics of safe spaces on college campuses claim that people in these spaces isolate themselves from those who disagree with their ideas. Ali and the Roestone Collective both argue that safe spaces carry an inherent contradiction, as they need to discriminate against certain groups and can never be perfectly safe. This thought may apply to physical spaces, but does it also apply to video game spaces?

Video games allow the notion of safety to take on new and unique dimensions. They provide players with ‘half-real’ spaces (Juul, 2011), where the rules and mechanics are grounded in reality, yet the worlds and narratives they navigate are fictional. This duality allows games to serve as ‘potential spaces’, which are described by Winnicott (1991) as temporary spaces between the inside and the outside; spaces that are neither objectively real nor purely in our heads, but instead touch on both. This potential space can exist between individuals, but also, in the case of video games, between players and NPCs (Non-Player Characters), which means that it can also be a source of affect (see, for example, Schallegger, 2020). Video games can thus be seen as half-real potential spaces, which allow players to safely explore identities, emotions, and experiences that might be inaccessible or unsafe in the real world (Kriss, 2016: 5). While the risk of real-world harassment still

exists in online situations, for many, particularly those from marginalised groups, video games offer a space to reclaim agency and find empowerment in ways that might not be possible for them otherwise.

This chapter focuses on the ‘ergodic’ (i.e. non-trivial) act of navigating a non-linear medium – walking in video games – and how it can construct a sense of safety (Aarseth, 1997). Using selected games, we highlight different aspects of walking in them and use the concept of safe spaces to analyse how this activity creates opportunities and experiences for specific vulnerable or marginalised player groups. As such, we have split this chapter into five distinctive parts before combining and summarising them at the end. In the first part, we look into empowerment and disempowerment through games like *Vampire: The Masquerade – Bloodlines* (Troika Games, 2004) and *Life is Strange* (Dontnod Entertainment, 2015). Insights into aspects of gender identity and queerness in character creators follow, looking at *Cyberpunk 2077* (CD Projekt Red, 2020) and *Baldur’s Gate 3* (Larian Studios, 2023). Then, the unexpected potential of catharsis through walking in horror games like *Silent Hill* (Team Silent, 1999) is investigated. The last two parts focus on gender identity in online games such as *Valorant* (Riot Games, 2020) and *Journey* (Thatgamecompany, 2012), as well as unique aspects of walking through games for neurodivergent players by looking into *Firewatch* (Campo Santo, 2016) and *Hellblade: Senua’s Sacrifice* (Ninja Theory, 2017). We also provide comments from users of the popular online platform Reddit (Reddit Community, 2005-2024) as anecdotal evidence for some of the topics we discuss. To protect the privacy of the quoted users, we do not name or reference them directly.

Games that have been labelled ‘walking simulators’ are often also considered to be female-gendered or inherently queer by mainstream gamer culture (Kagen, 2022: 6) – and thus also worth less than other games. We want to note that, while this chapter deals with these topics as well, the focus does not lie on how genres or walking mechanics in games are interpreted or portrayed by players. Instead, we want to highlight how the concept of walking – which includes many types of movement – in video games of various genres can showcase how these games create or endanger safe spaces for specific player identities.

As the concept of safe spaces continues to evolve, we think that understanding its application within video games is beneficial for players, game designers, and scholars. This chapter aims to contribute to this understanding by offering analysis and suggestions regarding how video games can be designed to function as safe spaces. A summary of these suggestions can be found at the end of this chapter. We hope that these ideas continue to be included in games, thus potentially enabling players to navigate complex identities, emotions, and social dynamics in a controlled and supportive environment.

Safety and power: the empowerment and disempowerment of walking

In video games, the simple act of walking can become a powerful tool for player empowerment. Walking, especially when embodied through a powerful avatar, allows players to navigate environments that might be dangerous or inaccessible to them in real life. This transformation of mundane actions into empowering experiences is particularly evident when players take on roles that challenge their real-world vulnerabilities. For example, walking as a powerful avatar through the streets at night, a scenario often associated with fear or discomfort for many individuals in real life, becomes an opportunity to reclaim agency and assert control in the virtual world.

This section explores how video games can both empower and disempower players through the mechanics of walking. By examining *Vampire: The Masquerade – Bloodlines* (Troika Games, 2004) and *Life is Strange* (Dontnod Entertainment, 2015), we analyse how walking as an avatar allows players to engage with environments from positions of power, offering a safe space to explore identities and experiences that may be unsafe or inaccessible in real life. However, as these games demonstrate, the empowerment provided by walking can be paradoxical, sometimes reinforcing traditional power dynamics or exposing the limitations of player agency at the same time.

Walking as empowerment in *Vampire: The Masquerade – Bloodlines*

In *Vampire: The Masquerade – Bloodlines*, a first-person action role-playing game, players navigate the dark, often dangerous streets of Los Angeles as a powerful vampire, exemplifying how the act of walking can be transformed into an experience of empowerment. By embodying a vampire – a figure traditionally associated with power, autonomy, and fearlessness – players gain a unique form of agency that contrasts with their potential real-world vulnerabilities. As Déborah (2020: 34) notes in her exploration of female vampires, these figures provide a powerful means for women and queer individuals to reclaim agency, challenging and resisting societal constraints. Walking through the game's atmospheric urban landscapes at night, the player, especially when playing as a female vampire, experiences a sense of control and dominance that defies usual fears associated with walking alone as a woman in real life. This role reversal allows players to safely explore scenarios that might be dangerous in reality, offering a form of empowerment within a virtual space – a safe space. The empowerment is particularly resonant for women and queer individuals, as vampires symbolise strength and authority that transcend traditional gender boundaries, subverting the patriarchal norms that historically prioritise male physical dominance.

The empowerment derived from this experience is deeply tied to the player's relationship with their avatar. Klevjer (2006) argues that the avatar is not just a tool for interaction but an embodiment of the player's agency, mediating their interaction with the virtual world in a way that makes the player feel in control. However, the relationship between the player and the avatar can go even deeper. As Banks (2015) describes, in some cases, the avatar functions as a 'symbiote', where both the player and the avatar engage in a process of mutual influence and identity formation. This symbiotic relationship is not merely about projection, but about the player and avatar becoming more alike, often moving toward an ideal self. In the real world, walking alone at night, especially for women and other minorities, often involves a heightened sense of vulnerability and fear. However, *Vampire: The Masquerade – Bloodlines* subverts this by allowing players to experience the power dynamics from the opposite perspective – where they are the predator, not the prey. This role reversal serves as a prime example of empowerment found through safe spaces in video games.

The paradox of disempowerment in *Life is Strange*

Life is Strange, a series of story-driven adventure games, presents a complex exploration of empowerment through its protagonist, Max Caulfield, who can rewind time. While this ability initially provides a sense of power and control, the narrative quickly undermines it, placing Max in situations where her abilities are either ineffective or lead to tragic

outcomes. While walking as Max, through her life and through time, players can experience both empowerment as a teenage girl with supernatural powers, as well as powerlessness when faced with societal and personal constraints. These walking sequences often place Max in liminal spaces (e.g. school halls, empty streets, and dreamlike environments), where her agency is limited or illusory. The act of walking becomes symbolic of Max's struggle to assert control in a world where her choices are constantly undermined.

This narrative choice can be seen as a broader critique of how agency is often illusory for women, who may be granted tools of empowerment but are simultaneously constrained and disempowered by societal expectations and systemic inequalities. Despite her supernatural abilities, Max is subjected to the same fears and dangers that many women face, highlighting the limitations of agency within a patriarchal framework. Maja (2019: 49), as well as Oktavanya and Panjaitan (2019: 22), note that the game critiques societal norms that constrain female autonomy, yet it also reinforces traditional gender roles by positioning Max as a sacrificial figure whose powers ultimately contribute to her disempowerment rather than liberation. Additionally, the depiction of Max's queerness, particularly in her relationship with Chloe, has been criticised for conforming to heteronormative expectations and catering to the male gaze (i.e. sexualising lesbianism and viewing women as sexual objects) rather than fully embracing her queer identity as empowering (Oktavanya and Panjaitan, 2019: 24). This tension between empowerment and disempowerment underscores the challenges women and queer individuals face in navigating identities within dominant cultural narratives.

Both *Vampire: The Masquerade – Bloodlines* and *Life is Strange* provide strong examples of how video games can empower female characters in traditionally vulnerable positions. In *Bloodlines*, players take on the role of a powerful vampire, subverting common fears associated with walking alone at night by granting the player strength and autonomy beyond the confines of gender. Meanwhile, *Life is Strange* empowers players through the ability to control time, allowing a teenage girl to navigate and potentially alter perilous situations, offering a sense of control in a narrative that often places her in disempowering circumstances.

These games present contrasting yet complementary perspectives on how embodying a powerful avatar can serve as both a mechanism for empowerment and a reflection of disempowerment. *Bloodlines* allows players to reclaim agency in spaces typically associated with fear and vulnerability, while *Life is Strange* uses its time-rewinding mechanic to explore the fragility of empowerment, showing how even those with extraordinary abilities can be undermined by the structures and narratives that surround them. Although games can offer safe spaces for players to explore different scenarios and aspects of their identities, they also have the potential to reinforce the very societal structures they aim to critique. By examining these two games, we gain a deeper understanding of how the act of walking in video games is not just about movement through space but often also about navigating an intricate balance between safety, power, and vulnerability. In the next section, we examine how players can be empowered by walking as characters that they design themselves.

Walking safely as yourself: character creators and queerness

Video games have increasingly become spaces where players can try out aspects of identity in ways that might not be possible in the real world. Aside from narrative aspects like

occupation or country of origin, more intimate aspects of identity, such as gender and sexuality, can also be explored. Extensive character creators in role-playing games like *Cyberpunk 2077* (CD Projekt Red, 2020) and *Baldur's Gate 3* (Larian Studios, 2023), or even the absence of such, as in *Rust* (Facepunch Studios, 2018), can provide players with the tools to experiment with and embody their gender identity in a virtual space. This ability to 'walk' as one's true or desired self in a game can be particularly powerful for transgender and gender diverse (TGD) players, offering a sense of safety, affirmation, and freedom from discrimination (Kriss, 2016: 5). This judgment-free environment allows TGD players to explore gender and different appearances, experience internal and external validation, and immerse themselves in a different reality – escapism, to a perfect safe space (McKenna et al., 2024: 29). It is noteworthy that games with less extensive character creators, e.g. *Animal Crossing: New Horizons* (Nintendo, 2020), also allow for queer self-expression and community-building – oftentimes by transforming the goals and tools provided by the game to serve them better (i.e. 'queering' the game) (Street, 2017: 35; Blanco-Fernández and Moreno, 2023: 16).

The power of character creation in *Cyberpunk 2077*

Character creators are not just about customisation; they are about the players' identities. In *Cyberpunk 2077*, a futuristic first-person role-playing game, players have the ability to mix and match features from the traditional gender binary, such as body types (see Figure 1), genitalia, and voice tones (see Figure 2), to create characters that potentially represent their personal or aspirational gender identity. Although the limitation of options to the gender binary is problematic, the flexibility of this mix-and-match system allows players to step into the shoes of a character that potentially resonates more with their sense of self, whether that reflects their current identity or an exploration of what might be possible. The game also offers romance options with various characters who have pre-defined sexualities, thus restricting which ones are available to the player in a

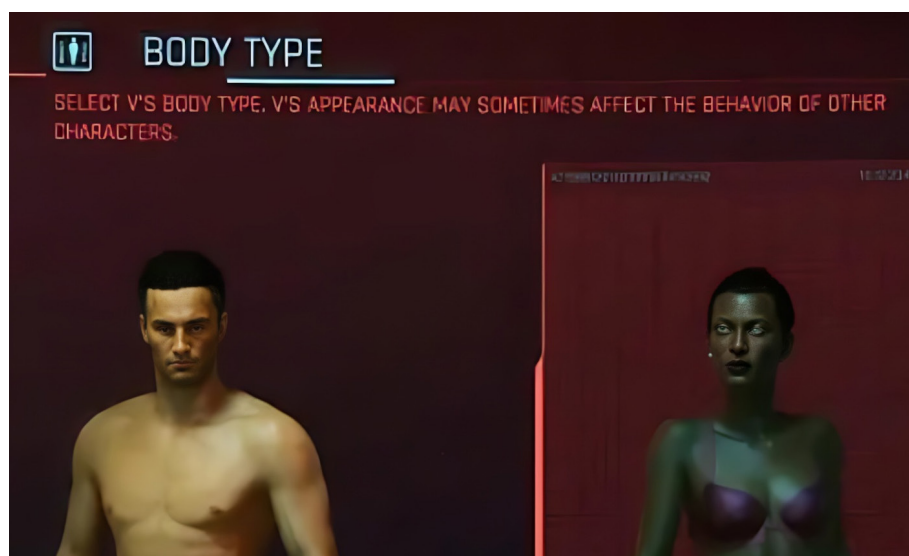


Figure 1. Options for body types in *Cyberpunk 2077*. Source: Walker (2020).

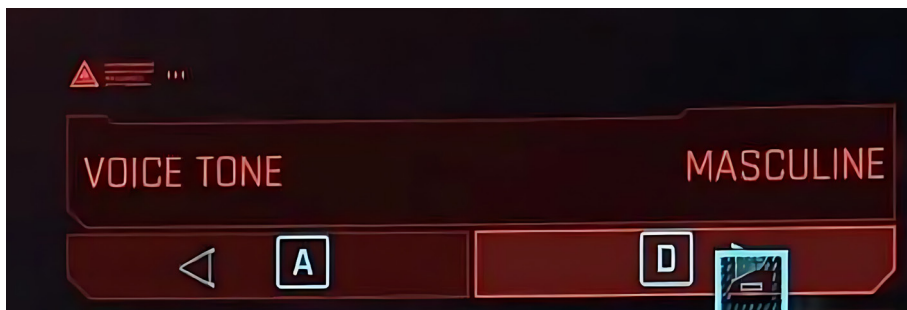


Figure 2. Separate options for voice tones in *Cyberpunk 2077*. Source: Walker (2020).

playthrough. However, what determines the availability of romance is not the players' chosen genitalia but their gender presentation, i.e., their voice and body type. While limiting NPC sexuality in this way can serve to make games more realistic, there are also other approaches, such as in *Baldur's Gate 3*, as discussed in the next section.

For TGD players, the ability to create a character that reflects their gender identity can be an affirming experience. It allows them to see themselves in the game world, to interact with it as their true self, and to experiment with identities in a space that feels safe and free from the judgments that often accompany real-world interactions. Furthermore, they get to experience being accepted by others (NPCs) for who they are and present as within the game world, without the constant threat of criticism, cynicism, or doubt.

Safe spaces and representation in *Baldur's Gate 3*

Baldur's Gate 3, an isometric role-playing game based on *Dungeons and Dragons*, offers an extensive character creator, which allows players to choose not just physical characteristics – such as their body type and looks, but also their character's gender identity and voice (see Figure 3). The explicit choice of identity also affects the pronouns NPCs use for the player character in conversation – in a fully-voiced video game. Players have praised *Baldur's Gate 3* for its detailed character creator, which not only allows them to create a character that looks like them but also feels like them. This deeper level of immersion is especially beneficial for TGD players who often struggle to find representation in media that aligns with their experiences and identities.

As opposed to other games with romanceable NPCs, such as *Cyberpunk 2077*, *Baldur's Gate 3* does not restrict players' romance options based on their gender, and all potential love interests are available to all player characters. This 'Avatar-Sexuality' (Lippitz, 2020: 162) of NPCs can cause issues, such as unrealistic expectations for reality. However, it can also be considered as a form of protection for players from being rejected based on their gender presentation, which can be particularly unpleasant and traumatic for TGD people. Although respectful rejection should be possible in the context of safe spaces, we consider this approach to be more graceful.

The challenges and innovations of *Rust*

Compared to the aforementioned games, the online survival multiplayer game *Rust* handles character identity very differently, as certain physical characteristics, including gender, are

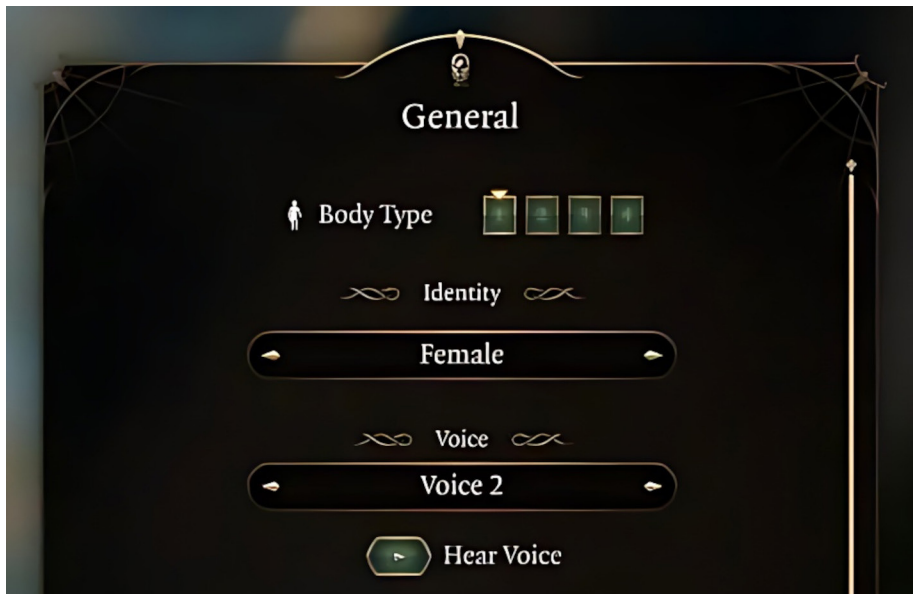


Figure 3. Separate options for body type, identity, and voice in *Baldur's Gate 3*. Source: Carpou (2023).

automatically assigned to players, randomly and permanently. This approach creates novel dynamics between players and forces them to engage with gender in a way that can be both challenging and eye-opening. The random assignment of a character's gender highlights the fluidity of gender identity, sparking discussions on identity and representation in games. The developers of the game have stated that the discomfort that players experience when playing a character that does not match their gender identity has always been felt by women playing games and that they consciously steered away from character creators for players (Donnelly, 2016). While this can enable some players to gain new insights, it also causes strongly adverse reactions (Euteneuer, 2016: 8). As new social dynamics form in-game based on assigned gender, those who have to live through such issues in real life will most likely not want to experience such harassment in video games as well. Even though it is certainly thought-provoking, this system can thus be seen as an antithesis to safe spaces for women and TGD players.

Out of the three games analysed here, we argue that *Baldur Gate 3* handles the safe-space aspects for marginalised players the best. In the next section, we shift the focus away from player characters and look at game worlds instead.

Feeling safe in unsafe environments: the catharsis of walking

Video games have long been recognised for their ability to evoke powerful emotions, serving as platforms for players to explore and process complex feelings. The *Silent Hill* series by Team Silent (1999), a psychological horror franchise, exemplifies this capacity through its evocative use of atmosphere, narrative, and gameplay mechanics. Particularly notable is the way in which the series invites players to walk through its eerie, desolate environments – an experience that can be both unsettling and cathartic, especially for those dealing with emotional challenges such as depression.

The catharsis of walking in *Silent Hill*

Silent Hill delves into deep psychological themes such as guilt, grief, and redemption. In many of the games, the protagonist, often driven by personal demons and emotional turmoil, walks through the foggy streets of the eponymous town (see Figure 4), encountering creatures and settings that are symbolic representations of their inner struggles. This parallelism between the game's environment and the protagonist's emotional state can extend to the player, especially if they are experiencing similar emotions and mental states.

For many players suffering from depression, the act of walking through *Silent Hill*'s environments can provide a form of emotional release or catharsis. According to the theory of catharsis, as outlined by Aristotle (335 BCE), engaging with intense emotional content – whether through art, literature, or now, video games – allows individuals to experience and process their emotions in a controlled manner. In the *Silent Hill* series, this is achieved by immersing players in a world that reflects their own fears and anxieties, yet allows them to confront these emotions in a way that feels safe and manageable.

Some players who have played games from the *Silent Hill* series, particularly *Silent Hill 2* (Team Silent, 2001), describe the experience as therapeutic during periods of depression. Posts on this theme can readily be found on Reddit. As one user from the 'r/silenthill' subreddit noted, playing *Silent Hill 2* during a dark period in their life made them feel like they were 'on a different level of depression', yet they found comfort in the game's gloomy streets and spooky sounds. Another user shared their experience, explaining how *Silent Hill 2* became their 'go-to game for playing when I'm depressed'. They describe playing the game as 'a miserable and uncomfortable experience', but by the end, they felt 'stronger and more assured' that they could deal with their issues. The game, according to this player, does not necessarily make you feel happier; rather, 'it gives you the mental tools to deal with issues'. This sentiment is echoed by others who find the bleak atmosphere of the game calming, offering a space to confront and work through their depression in a safe environment. These perspectives allow us to see the therapeutic potential of walking

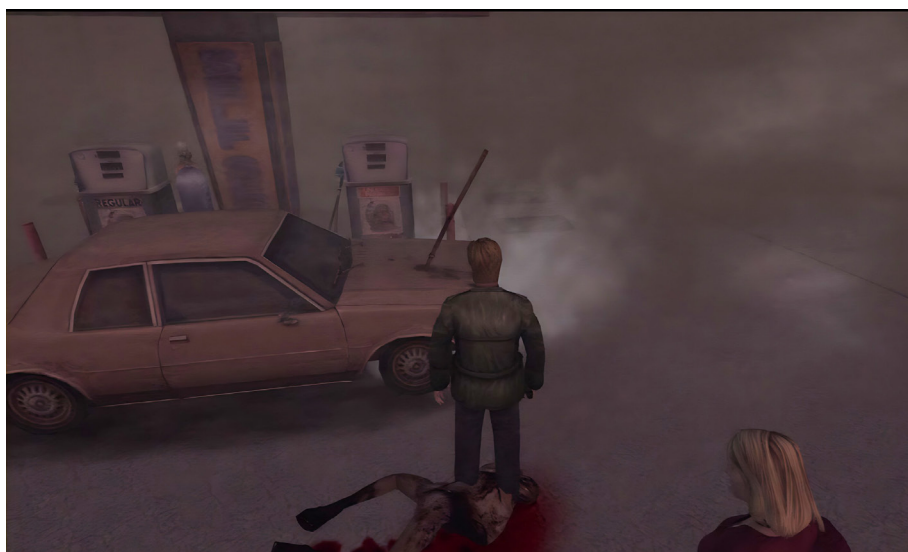


Figure 4. The foggy streets in *Silent Hill 2*. Source: Madrigal (2018).

through the streets of *Silent Hill*, not by offering escapism or distraction, but by confronting the player with (metaphors of) their fears and anxieties in a way that feels safe and manageable. After all, maintaining control and safety are considered important aspects of what makes horror media enjoyable (Bantinaki, 2012: 386; Gaut, 1993: 339).

Walking as a therapeutic experience

The cathartic experience in *Silent Hill* is not limited to narrative alone; it is deeply tied to the act of walking through the game's unsettling environments. The slow, deliberate pace at which the protagonist moves through the town allows players to engage with the environment at their own pace, reflecting on their emotions as they navigate the game's challenges. This aligns with findings by Bopp, Mekler, and Opwis (2016: 3003), who argue that emotionally moving moments in games often arise from the player's interaction with the game's environment and mechanics, not just its narrative. Furthermore, research by Gowler and Iacovides (2019: 334) suggests that horror games, in particular, can evoke complex emotions such as guilt, shame, and relief, which are critical components of the cathartic process. In *Silent Hill*, these emotions are amplified by the game's use of unsettling imagery and sound design, which potentially mirror the player's internal state and create a powerful emotional resonance. The ability to control the protagonist's movements, even in a world that feels overwhelmingly hostile, offers players a sense of agency and control over their emotions – an 'anxiety that I have control over', as one player described it.

Understanding how games like *Silent Hill* evoke catharsis could also lead to the design of games specifically aimed at therapeutic outcomes. As noted by Ferguson et al. (2014: 765), the concept of catharsis has been applied to violent video games, where it often became synonymous with power fantasies. However, its application in other genres offers a promising avenue for further research. In psychological horror, which subverts the idea of a power fantasy and often revolves around powerlessness, different forms of catharsis can be found. By harnessing the power of cathartic gameplay, developers could create experiences that not only entertain but also provide meaningful emotional support for players.

The *Silent Hill* series exemplifies how video games can serve as safe spaces for players to explore and process complex emotions. The game's environments are hostile and unsettling, including grotesque imagery, cryptic puzzles, and disturbing radio noise whenever monsters are nearby. Through the act of walking in these environments, players – especially those going through a difficult time themselves – can achieve a sense of catharsis, confronting their feelings in a controlled and reflective manner. As the field of game studies continues to evolve, we think that the therapeutic potential of cathartic gameplay offers an exciting opportunity to explore how games can contribute to emotional well-being and mental health in unconventional ways. In the next section, we explore a dimension that does not apply to the single-player games that have been analysed so far – that of interactions between players in online spaces.

Safety to interact: perceiving players' gender identities in online spaces

Online multiplayer games have become a primary space for social interaction, where players from diverse backgrounds come together to collaborate, compete, and communicate. However, these spaces are not always safe or welcoming, particularly for players whose gender identities deviate from the perceived norm (Consalvo, 2012; Taylor, 2012; Cote,

2017) – players are assumed to be heterosexual, cisgender males until proven otherwise (Lukianov, 2014: 75). The experience of gendered harassment and discrimination in online spaces is well-documented, with women and non-binary individuals often facing the most toxic behaviour. This section explores how online multiplayer video games like *Valorant* (Riot Games, 2020) and *Journey* (Thatgamecompany, 2012) attempt to address these issues, and how game design can play a crucial role in creating safer environments for all players.

In a comparatively early piece, Jenkins (2006: 213) explains how video games historically centred around ‘boy culture’. He emphasises the need for developing video game spaces that are not gender-coded and claims that many related issues require changes not only to video game design but also society in general. While there was hope that the increasing diversity of video game audiences would automatically improve the situation regarding harassment issues (Cote, 2017: 137), the reality turned out to be different. We do not have any definite answers as to what causes players to behave this way, but predicting such conduct has become feasible, both by profiling in-game and offline behaviour. Research has shown that masculinity and social dominance orientation (beliefs about inequality between groups) are indicators of sexism towards women in video games, whereas time spent playing games and general empathy showed no significant correlations (Fox and Tang, 2014: 317). However, time spent playing games was shown to be an indicator of general harassment and misbehaviour (Tang and Fox, 2016: 517).

An important factor when it comes to harassment in online games is voice communication. Based on how players sound and how they are perceived, they are linguistically profiled by other players, who speculate on aspects of their identities, such as race or gender. This, in turn, often causes increased racist, sexist, and othering behaviour among players (Gray, 2020: 148). To guarantee safe spaces for marginalised players in online games, harassment has to be stopped, and while changing society is difficult, changing game design can go a long way.

The challenge of gender perception in *Valorant*

Valorant, a team-based first-person shooter, is one of many examples of games where gendered interactions can become a significant source of stress for certain player groups. The game’s emphasis on voice communication for team coordination can often expose players to gender-based harassment. Similar to the experiences of female players interviewed by Lukianov (2014), women of the community have reported hesitancy to use voice chat, fearing that revealing their gender might subject them to derogatory comments, exclusion, or even targeted harassment. Another layer of stress is added by the pressure to perform well in order to avoid reinforcing negative gender stereotypes (e.g. women being afraid that their in-game performance will shape other players’ perception of all women). Situations like this exemplify how the design of communication systems in online games can inadvertently contribute to an unsafe environment for marginalised players.

Aside from Riot Games, the developers of *Valorant*, having a long history of trying to stop harassment and fostering diversity in their communities (Cote, 2017: 152), the game was chosen for analysis in this section as representative of a wide variety of online multiplayer games featuring fast-paced, team-based combat. Quick communication to relay information to teammates is important for performing well, which usually causes voice-based chat to be the preferred mode of communication. However, other systems have been implemented, such as non-verbal gestures, dialogue wheels that allow for quick selection of

often-used pre-recorded phrases, and ping systems for players to place temporary markers with different meanings on the game's map. Increased use of these forms of communication has been shown to correlate with player performance (Leavitt, Keegan, and Clark, 2016), which implies the potential of using such non-verbal tools over verbal communication exclusively. Restricting oneself to non-verbal communication allows for one's identity to stay obscured, thus potentially increasing safety. Unfortunately, there are at least two issues with this approach – one is that gender identity performance can still occur non-verbally in video games (Healey, 2020). The other issue lies in minorities refusing to use voice chat, which reduces their visibility and thus ends up reinforcing hegemonic masculinity in video games. With male players continuing to use such systems, a feedback loop known as the 'spiral of silence' emerges (Noelle-Neumann, 1974), further increasing the perception of all players being male. This effect could potentially be reduced by restricting communication for all players instead – which is why we suggest that game designers look into alternative ways of conveying information between players.

***Journey*: a non-verbal, gender-neutral safe space**

In stark contrast to the environment in *Valorant*, *Journey* offers a radically different approach to online interaction. The game has two randomly assigned players traverse a vast desert together without knowing anything about each other. Instead of fostering an adversarial relationship, the game encourages collaboration between players. No direct chat functionality is available, and the characters were intentionally designed to be genderless (Kobylski et al., 2017). Players communicate solely through movement and simple musical chimes ('chirps'), fostering a sense of connection without the need for words (see Figure 5). This design choice creates a unique safe space for players of any gender in an online game. They are free to explore and interact without fear of judgment or hostility based on their gender identity. The game presents the environment and other players as more than objects to be manipulated, changing the relationship from one of otherness to one of cooperation and mutual support, which further enhances feelings of safety and community (Plessis, 2018).

The success of *Journey* in creating a non-threatening, inclusive environment suggests that game designers can mitigate the risks associated with gendered interactions by



Figure 5. Audio-visual interaction between players by 'chirping' in *Journey*. Source: Kobylski et al. (2017).

rethinking how players communicate and present themselves in-game. While this approach may not be suitable for all types of games, it shows how alternative communication methods can foster safer spaces in online environments. For many players, games like *Valorant* add the stress of presenting oneself to others on top of the stress of competition. Game designers have the ability to counteract such aspects, e.g., by finding alternative forms of interaction that reduce the focus on gender. *Journey* demonstrates that such approaches not only have the potential to prevent harassment but also encourage a more collaborative and empathetic player experience. The game's painting-like visual style is also a good example of sensory-friendly aesthetics – which are further explored in the next section.

Safe to explore the world: walking safely as a neurodivergent player

Neurodivergent players – e.g. those with autism, ADHD, or dyslexia – have been shown to enjoy video games for various reasons, including escapism and therapeutic benefits (Zolyomi and Schmalz, 2017; Kommander, 2023). However, creating an inclusive environment requires thoughtful design choices that cater to diverse sensory and cognitive needs. For these players, navigating game environments that are sensory-friendly spaces and which reduce sensory overload while still being visually and auditorily engaging, can transform their experiences from overwhelming to enjoyable. This section looks into ways in which games can allow players to explore such balanced environments at their own pace and in a way that feels comfortable and manageable. We explore how *The Legend of Zelda: Breath of the Wild* (Nintendo, 2017) and *Firewatch* (Campo Santo, 2016) offer sensory-friendly environments while also considering the challenges posed by certain game mechanics in titles such as *Hellblade: Senua's Sacrifice* (Ninja Theory, 2017) and *Until Dawn* (Supermassive Games, 2015).

Exploring sensory-friendly environments

For neurodivergent players, environments that are visually and aurally stimulating without being overwhelming can provide a unique form of solace and enjoyment, which can be difficult to achieve in the real world. *The Legend of Zelda: Breath of the Wild* and *Firewatch* are examples of games that can offer such experiences.

In *Breath of the Wild*, a third-person open-world adventure game, players explore vast, picturesque landscapes that can serve as a form of visual 'stimming' – a self-soothing behaviour often observed in neurodivergent individuals (Kapp et al., 2019). As one player on the 'r/autism' subreddit shared, 'I play botw/totk as a stim. Even just picking up items, the little sound effect and the rhythm of it, it's soothing'. Another player shared their experience, noting how the game offers a break from overstimulation: 'It's not just for taking a break from overstimulating games. It's also therapeutic in general'. The game's expansive world, filled with lush forests, serene waters, and towering mountains, invites players to immerse themselves in nature's beauty, which can be both calming and invigorating. This open-world design allows them to explore at their own pace, reducing the pressure and sensory overload that more fast-paced games might induce – a sentiment echoed on *Reddit* by users who found *Breath of the Wild* especially beneficial: 'I really like open-world games, farming simulators, cozycore games that allow me to escape from the real world and become immersed in the virtual world'. Another user agreed by saying, 'Just walking around Hyrule is really calming'.

Similarly, *Firewatch*, also an adventure game but without combat – often called a ‘Walking Simulator’, offers a rich, natural environment where players can navigate through a landscape of forests, lakes, and mountains. The game’s emphasis on exploration and narrative over combat or time-sensitive challenges creates a relaxed pace, making it accessible to neurodivergent players who might find other games too stressful. The minimalist design, combined with ambient sounds of nature, allows for an environment that is both engaging and soothing, providing a virtual escape that is free from the sensory demands of the real world.

Unintended hurdles in game design for neurodivergent players

While some games offer welcoming environments, others present significant challenges for neurodivergent players due to certain design choices. Here, *Hellblade: Senua’s Sacrifice* and *Until Dawn* serve as examples of how game mechanics may inadvertently create barriers.

Hellblade: Senua’s Sacrifice, an action-adventure game lauded for its portrayal of mental health and psychosis, seemingly features a mechanic that can be especially distressing: permanent death and the loss of save game data. Although it ultimately does not take effect, the game introduces a ‘dark rot’ mechanic, where rot grows each time the player fails, supposedly leading to a permanent loss of progress, which can heighten stress for players who already struggle with high levels of anxiety or fear of failure. A *Reddit* user on the ‘r/autism’ subreddit reflects on their gaming preferences, expressing a general dislike for games in which they can die or encounter high-stress situations, stating,

I pretty much dislike playing video games as a whole. I find almost every video game too difficult. The reasons include difficulty coordinating my hands on the controls, speed-dependent game mechanics, being unable to determine the next step, and so on. I don’t like games that can scare me, which pretty much rules out anything with a sense of urgency or the possibility to ‘die’.

This demonstrates how the constant pressure of potentially losing all progress in *Hellblade* can overshadow the game’s immersive narrative, making it less accessible to those who might benefit from a more forgiving gameplay experience. Similarly, *Until Dawn* includes a mechanic where players avoid being detected by enemies by remaining physically still for extended periods of time, as their controller tracks their movement (see Figure 6). For neurodivergent players and those with neurological issues, the requirement to physically suppress movement can be especially challenging. The tension created by this mechanic, while effective in enhancing the horror experience, may exclude players who find it difficult to remain still or control involuntary movements.

Lastly, certain game genres, settings, or perspectives, such as first-person shooters or games with complex graphics, can be inaccessible to neurodivergent players who may prefer simpler, less overwhelming games. Another ‘r/autism’ subreddit user shares, ‘I love playing Jump ‘n Run games such as Megaman X or Super Mario World for SNES. I also like RPGs like Pokémon, especially the old ones. I’m not able to play games with a first-person perspective (shooters etc.) and games with complex graphics’. These examples showcase different neurodivergent needs, which can be incorporated into game design. While the intention behind aspects like photo-realistic graphics is often to enhance immersion, they can inadvertently create barriers for players with different neurological makeups.



Figure 6. 'Don't Move'-Indicator in *Until Dawn*. Source: Until Dawn Wiki (2023).

To make video games more accessible and enjoyable for neurodivergent players, developers should aim to strike a balance between challenging gameplay and inclusivity. Offering customisable difficulty settings, sensory-friendly environments, and alternative mechanics allows them to cater to a broader range of players. By understanding and addressing the unique needs of neurodivergent players, the video game industry can continue to evolve into a more inclusive space where all players feel safe to explore, interact, and enjoy the virtual worlds created for them.

Conclusion: designing intersectional safe spaces

The concept of safe spaces in video games is multifaceted, encompassing various design elements that allow players to explore, interact, and express themselves without fear of judgment or discrimination. By carefully considering these elements, developers can create environments that empower players across different identities and needs, ultimately fostering an inclusive and supportive gaming experience. Furthermore, exclusion on the same level as in physical safe spaces is not always necessary in video games. By consciously designing the ways in which players can communicate with each other, harmful behaviours can be discouraged and minimised. However, in games with chat or voice communication, strict moderation is required to create a safe space akin to separatist safe spaces. In this section, we summarise our findings and takeaways for developers and designers, which can also be found in Table 1.

Intersectional safe spaces in games require a nuanced approach to game design – one that is flexible, inclusive, and responsive to the diverse identities of players, recognising

GameDesign Element or Mechanic	Explanation or Impact	Game Examples
Inclusive Character Customisation	Allows players to create avatars that reflect their true or aspirational identities, fostering inclusivity and personal expression.	<i>Cyberpunk 2077</i> , <i>Baldur's Gate 3</i>
Sensory-Friendly Environments and Aesthetics	Creates audio-visual aesthetics with calming, yet stimulating effects. Avoids overwhelming neurodivergent players, and offers a sense of peace and engagement. E.g. low-contrast colours.	<i>The Legend of Zelda: Breath of the Wild</i> , <i>Firewatch</i>
Non-Gendered Communication and Interaction	Reduces gender-based discrimination by eliminating gender markers, enabling interactions that are free from preconceived biases.	<i>Journey</i>
Processing Emotions through Gameplay	Utilises narrative, aesthetics, and mechanics that allow players to process complex emotions in a controlled environment, offering relief and reflection.	<i>Silent Hill 2</i>
Empowerment through Avatar Representation	Empowers players by allowing them to embody strong, capable characters that reflect their identity. Provides a sense of agency and control.	<i>Vampire: The Masquerade- Bloodlines</i>

Table 1. Game design elements that foster safe spaces in video games.

the overlapping identities that players may hold, such as, for example, being both queer and neurodivergent. To support these intersectional identities, developers should strive to create games that offer multifaceted experiences while respecting and validating all players without privileging one aspect of identity over others. These efforts can start with diverse character creators, offering a wide range of customisation options that reflect various gender identities, body types, and skin tones. These tools can enable players to see themselves represented, thus fostering a sense of belonging and validation. This is crucial for creating an inclusive gaming environment where all players feel seen and respected. Avatars, as the player's representation within the game, fulfil a significant role in how players perceive themselves and their abilities. Empowering avatars – especially those that allow players to express their true selves – can provide a sense of agency and control. Optionality – the concept of allowing players to engage with only the aspects of a game that they wish to engage with, thus also increasing accessibility – invites more people to enjoy video games without directly excluding anyone.

Furthermore, the idea of cathartic gameplay offers another avenue for creating safe spaces. By mirroring players' emotional states or providing a sense of relief, such games enable players to process complex emotions in a controlled and supportive environment. This is particularly important for players dealing with depression, anxiety, or trauma, as these games provide a safe outlet for emotional release and healing. At the same time, neurodivergent-friendly game design is an oftentimes overlooked factor in making games more accessible to players with different needs. By incorporating elements like customisable control schemes, options for difficulty levels and time-sensitive events, and environments that reduce sensory overload, developers can create games that neurodivergent players can fully enjoy without unnecessary stress or anxiety. Lastly, we think that game design that de-emphasises the perception of gender identity online has the potential to significantly change the world of video games into a more inclusive environment. By focusing on non-gendered mechanics and interactions, developers can alleviate the pressure on players to conform to traditional gender norms. This approach can be particularly empowering for players who do not fit into conventional gender

categories, while also allowing for more novel, versatile, and open-ended experiences in video games.

We acknowledge that there are many other perspectives that deserve attention, including, but not limited to, the experiences of people with physical disabilities or invisible illnesses, plus-sized individuals, people of colour, those living in unsafe environments, displaced people, and immigrants. It is important to remember that singular safe spaces are never for everyone – they always have one or more specific target audiences. Video games are the same, and they do not need to cater to everyone at once. Nonetheless, by considering a wider range of perspectives, we can create better spaces – and better video games – for everyone. An example of such improvements can be found in subtitles, which are widely used in games nowadays, not only by those who are deaf or hard of hearing but also by players who simply prefer to read dialogue. This serves as a reminder that inclusive design benefits everyone, not just those with specific needs.

In conclusion, designing intersectional safe spaces in video games is not just about adding inclusive features – it is about rethinking the entire game experience to ensure that it is welcoming, supportive, and empowering for as many players as possible, regardless of their identity. By embracing this approach, developers can create games that not only entertain but also provide a safe space – a sanctuary for players to enjoy themselves and disconnect from reality, but also to explore their identities and emotions in a safe, inclusive, and empowering environment.

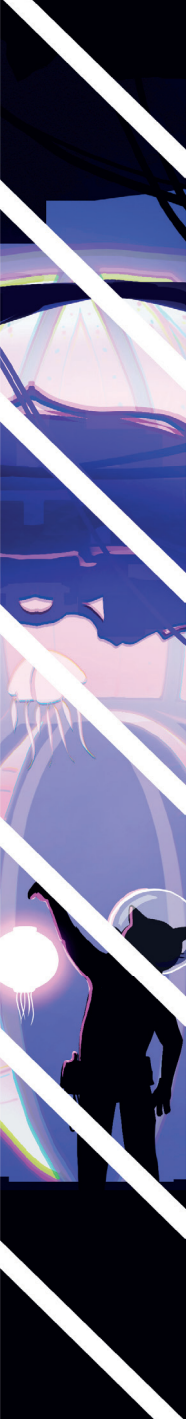
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EXPLORING NEW HORIZONS IN VIDEO GAME CULTURES

This book brings together a selection of papers delivered at the Video Game Cultures 2023 conference, held from 7 to 9 September 2023 at the University of Klagenfurt, Austria. An interdisciplinary collection drawing on disciplines from literary and cultural studies through to evolutionary psychology, this book critically investigates many developments in video game cultures, technologies, practices, texts, paratexts, and genres. Through examining ideas such as narrative and time, gender and sexuality, ethics and affect, and technology and spaces, our authors aim to expand our shared understanding of video games, and the cultures and communities which surround them.

The work presented here reflects authors at different points in their academic careers, and will appeal to a variety of readers, from those wanting to find out more about academic writing on video games, through to those with a focused scholarly interest in particular fields of enquiry. With sections addressing Queer Game Studies, Historical Game Studies, and Game Design Perspectives, alongside ideas of solidarity and kindness in video games, the collection speaks to numerous subfields within games research. The chapters within offer conclusions and recommendations for academics and other educators, for established and aspiring game designers, and for anyone interested in how games can be understood as meaningful contributors to our cultural lives.

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